Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'. The scoring in each parameter allows the students to make a comparative assessment of the colleges they wish to join and make more informed decisions.

One of the key factors impacting this decision is the return on investment (RoI) in education. Every parent and student is anxious to know the employment opportunities and potential remuneration a degree in a particular course can yield. You can find those details in the India Today Best Colleges survey, which provides information on colleges offering the best RoI, campus placements with the highest salary and also the lowest fee. AIIMS, for example, is not just the best institute for medical education, it also has the second lowest fee for MBBS courses across India.

## Best By Geography

As the All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) 2021-22 mapped, there is great geographical disparity within the 45,473 registered colleges in India—6,975 of which were set up between 2014 and 2022, or 870 colleges every year. With the highest number of colleges among the Top 10, Top 25 and Top 50 across all streams, Delhi NCR remains the hub of higher education in India, closely followed by Bengaluru. Karnataka, in fact, leads the states in terms of college density, with 62 colleges for every 100,000 people aged between 18 and 23 years, as per the AISHE report.

**27%**

**Extent to which enrolment in higher education has risen since 2014-15; female enrolment has increased by 32 per cent**

**28.4**

**Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in higher education for the 18-23-year age group. For females, it is 28.5**

Past legacy is responsible for a lot of this geographical disparity. Hence, the India Today Best Colleges Survey endeavours to focus not just on the colleges in big cities but also the relatively new colleges in newer cities, particularly those established in this century, which are showing incremental progress. Thus colleges from cities like Bhopal, Kanpur and Lucknow are finding a place among the Top 30, attesting to the democratisation of education.

The survey lists the top three colleges in several Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities, making it a more inclusive ranking of institutes of higher education. The number of participating colleges too has nearly doubled in the past six years—from 988 in 2018 to 1,779 this year. Educationists admit that this process has bred a competitive spirit among colleges from even the smaller cities. It provides them the motivation to excel even further.

Such regular innovations and additions, in fact, make the India Today Best Colleges Survey, conducted by reputed market research agency Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), an invaluable resource for young students. As another admission season descends upon us, it will help them cut through the clutter and line up the most suitable choices for them this summer. ■

METHODOLOGY

# How the Colleges were Ranked

With over 45,000 colleges across India, the 28th annual edition of India Today Group's ranking of best colleges in India intends to make critical career decisions easier for aspirants. Our ranking has come to be known as the gold standard for all stakeholders, including recruiters, parents, alumni, policy makers and institutions. Since 2018, the survey has been done in association with reputed Delhi-based market research agency Marketing & Development Research Associates (MDRA) and has been widely appreciated for its consistency. For this year, the groundwork was conducted between January and June. Colleges were ranked across 14 streams—Arts, Science, Commerce, Medical, Dental Sciences, Engineering, Architecture, Law, Mass Communication, Hotel Management, BBA, BCA, Social Work and Fashion Design.

During the objective ranking, MDRA carefully attuned more than 112 performance indicators in each stream to provide the most comprehensive and balanced comparisons of colleges. These indicators were clubbed into five broad pa-